THEATRE ▼

PERFORMANCE *With Purpose*

The IHC Theatre Festival *is a 10-day showcase where theatre becomes a mirror to society*

At Delhi's India Habitat Centre (IHC), theatre has never been just about performance. It has always been about provocation, empathy and conversation. Over the years, IHC has nurtured not only a loyal audience but also a fraternity of theatre-makers who return, season after season, to share their stories. That continuum finds new resonance this September with the IHC Theatre Festival 2025. From September 19 to 28, IHC will host 14 productions that push past entertainment to probe the anxieties of our times—from gender and caste to mental health, climate change and identity.

"The vision is of the theatre practitioners who have chosen to invest their passion in addressing issues that need to be highlighted," says Vidyun Singh, creative head–programmes at IHC. "Ours is the easy but important role of bringing these works to the public and encouraging the role of theatre in our arts."

The lineup is as diverse as it is daring. *Mehroon* opens the festival with a musical meditation on grief, love and fantasy, while *Kadambari* reimagines the intimate world of Tagore's muse. *Saanp Seedhi*, adapted from Anthony Shaffer's *Sleuth*, offers a taut thriller on ego and betrayal, balanced by *Khichik*, a comedy tracing decades of marital sparring. The Marathi play *Dagad Aani Mati* reflects the struggles of rural youth, while *Besharam Aadmi* uses humour to critique gender stereotypes. Among the most stirring works is *Nazar Ke Saamne*, devised by Freeda Theatre (in collaboration with Maara Collective), where women from marginalised communities in Madhya Pradesh share lived testimonies of caste discrimination. Singh calls it "the perfect testimonial for the power of theatre to make a difference".

In a city always in flux, the IHC Theatre Festival is more than an arts calendar event. It is a reminder of theatre's enduring role as society's conscience. ■

—Geetika Sachdev

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